

Companion Reading: Anscombe's Case Against Truman's Decision

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 2.01 — A Decision That Divided the World A guide to G.E.M. Anscombe, Mr. Truman's Degree (1957)

A note on this document: Anscombe's pamphlet is still under copyright, so this is not a primary-source excerpt like the Truman reading — it is a faithful paraphrase of her actual argument, with only occasional short phrases quoted directly and cited. If you want her exact wording throughout, read the PDF itself; this document is meant to prepare you for that reading, not replace it.

Who Anscombe Was, and Why She Wrote This

G.E.M. Anscombe was a philosopher at Oxford in 1956 when the university proposed to award Harry Truman an honorary degree. She opposed the award publicly, in a pamphlet addressed to her Oxford colleagues, on the grounds that Truman was responsible for what she considered two acts of mass murder. Her target was not really Truman's character or intentions. It was the specific moral claim that dropping the bombs was a defensible decision because of its results.

The Central Distinction: Killing as a Means Versus Killing as a Side Effect

Anscombe's argument turns on a distinction that runs through the whole deontological tradition. She grants that a military campaign can foreseeably kill civilians without that being murder — for instance, an attack aimed carefully at military targets like munitions factories or naval dockyards will predictably kill some innocent people nearby, but this is not murder, because the deaths are a foreseen side effect rather than the chosen means of achieving the goal.

Hiroshima and Nagasaki, she argues, were different in kind, not just in scale. The bombs were aimed at whole cities, and the deaths of the civilian population were not a side effect of attacking some other target — the mass killing of civilians *was* the mechanism by which the attack was supposed to work, terrifying Japan's government into surrender. On her view, this makes the case unambiguous rather than borderline: choosing to kill the innocent as a means to one's ends, she writes, is always murder.

Why "It Probably Saved Lives" Does Not Settle the Question

Anscombe anticipates the strongest consequentialist reply directly: that the bombings likely saved more lives than a land invasion of Japan would have cost, on both sides. She does not dispute this estimate. Her point is that this observation, even if true, answers the wrong question. Granting that an action produced a good outcome does not show that the action itself was permissible, if the action involved deliberately killing innocent people as the means to that outcome. She illustrates this with a deliberately uncomfortable comparison: if you had to

choose between boiling one baby alive and letting some much larger disaster befall a thousand people, most people sense that appealing to the disaster averted does not automatically make the first option acceptable. The scale of the good result, in other words, cannot simply purchase permission to do what would otherwise be considered murder.

Her Broader Target: A Trend in Moral Philosophy

Anscombe was not only criticizing Truman. She was criticizing what she saw as a drift in academic moral philosophy of her time — a tendency to treat no category of action, including the killing of the innocent, as absolutely off-limits, so long as the actor's stated motive or the balance of consequences could be made to look favorable enough. Her essay is often read today alongside her more famous academic paper "Modern Moral Philosophy" (1958), where she argues that a framework without firm, exceptionless prohibitions cannot really function as a moral framework at all.

Not a Pacifist Argument

It is worth being precise about what Anscombe is not saying. She explicitly rejects pacifism, which she considers a false doctrine — she believes killing in war can be legitimate, and that the state has real authority to order people to fight and to kill. Her objection to Hiroshima and Nagasaki is not that all killing in war is wrong. It is that this particular killing crossed a line that, in her view, no amount of good consequences can erase: the deliberate killing of the innocent as a chosen method, rather than an unintended side effect, of achieving one's goals.

For your discussion post: Anscombe's argument is one of the clearest examples in modern philosophy of a deontological objection built on the distinction between intended and merely foreseen harm. If you choose to write the deontological objection for your assignment, her essay — read in full, in the PDF you already have — is the strongest version of that case available to you. Notice, too, exactly where her argument would need the utilitarian to concede something and where the utilitarian has room to push back: is the distinction between "means" and "side effect" as clean as she suggests, especially in a case where the side effect is the entire point of the operation?